Happenings in Handmade

A CCI initiative

October 2024

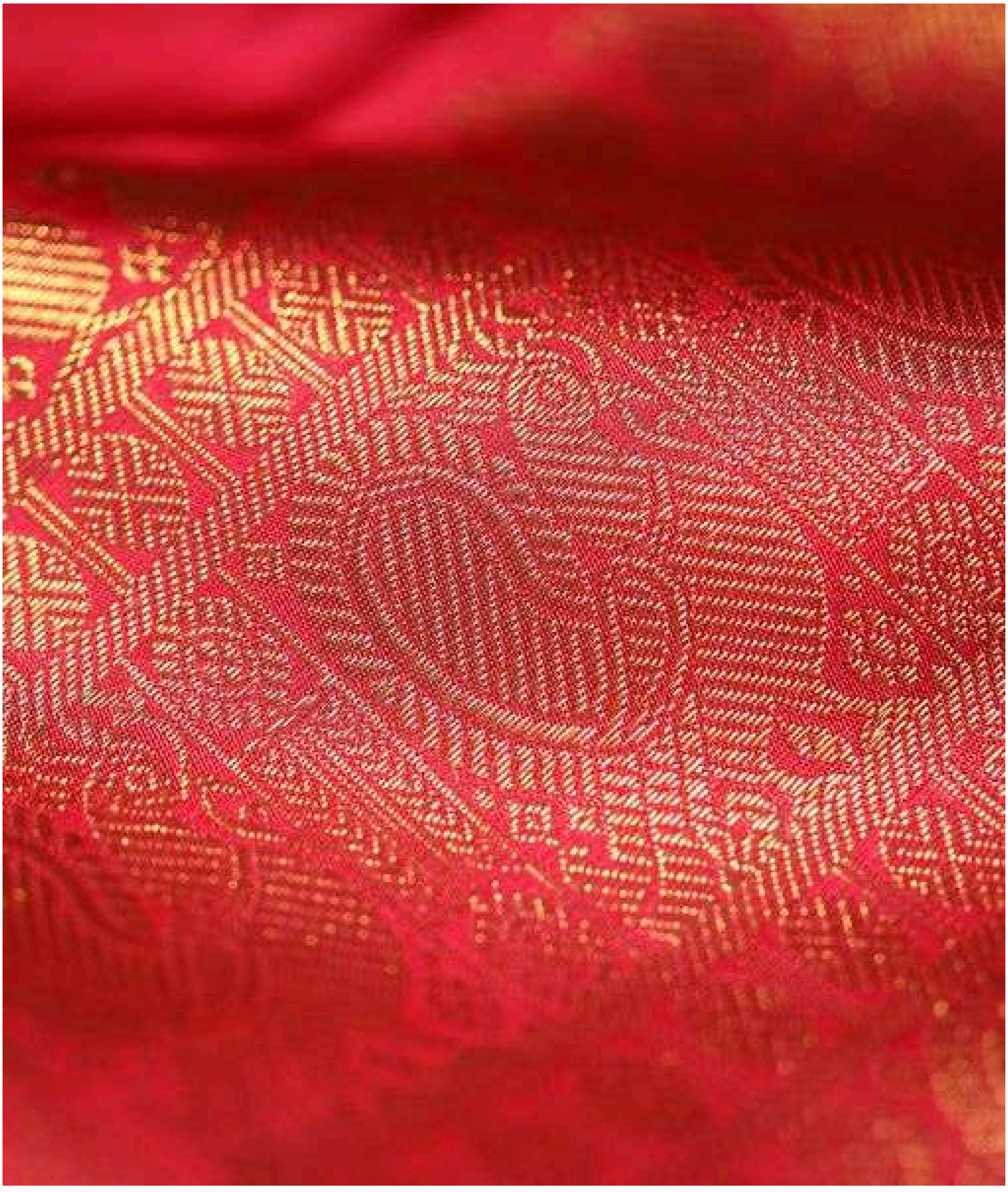
Where heaven and earth meet



The weavers of the Kancheepuram silk saree trace their ancestry to the sage Markandeya, master weaver to the gods.

While this may be more myth than fact, nonetheless it points to the hallowed status of this ‘queen of silks’, the lustrous pure mulberry yarn from which the sarees have been woven for nearly 12 centuries, consecrated by the gods.

Today, it is said that more than 5,000 artisan families are engaged in the craft. It is therefore only natural that the designs and motifs of Kancheepuram silk sarees are inspired by the region; with the twin influences of the part-forest, part-farmland and the scriptures and images of this ‘town of a thousand temples.’



MAYIL, the peacock, an emblem of grandeur and beauty.



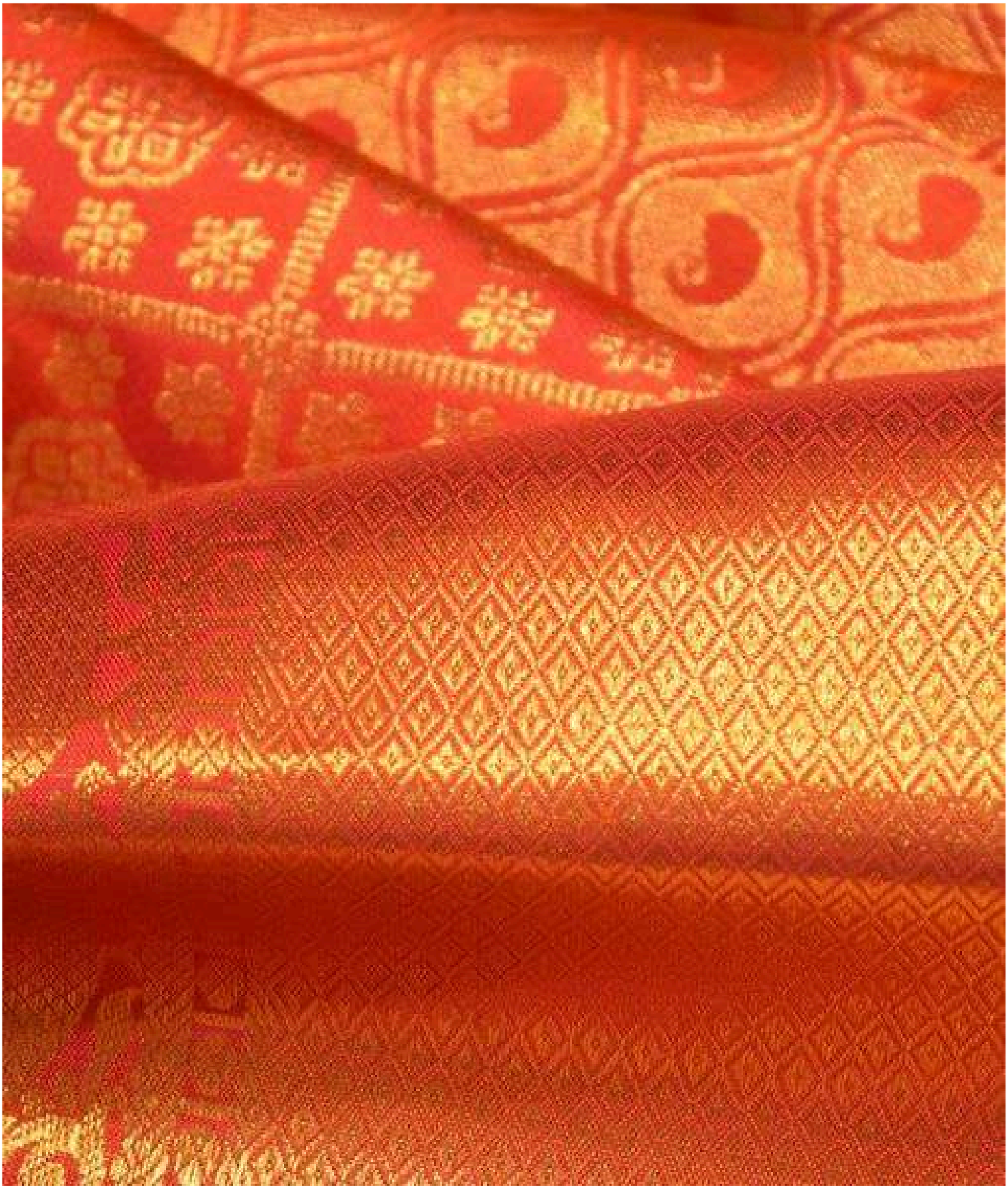
MAANGA, the paisley with a myriad variations…here with the mayil within



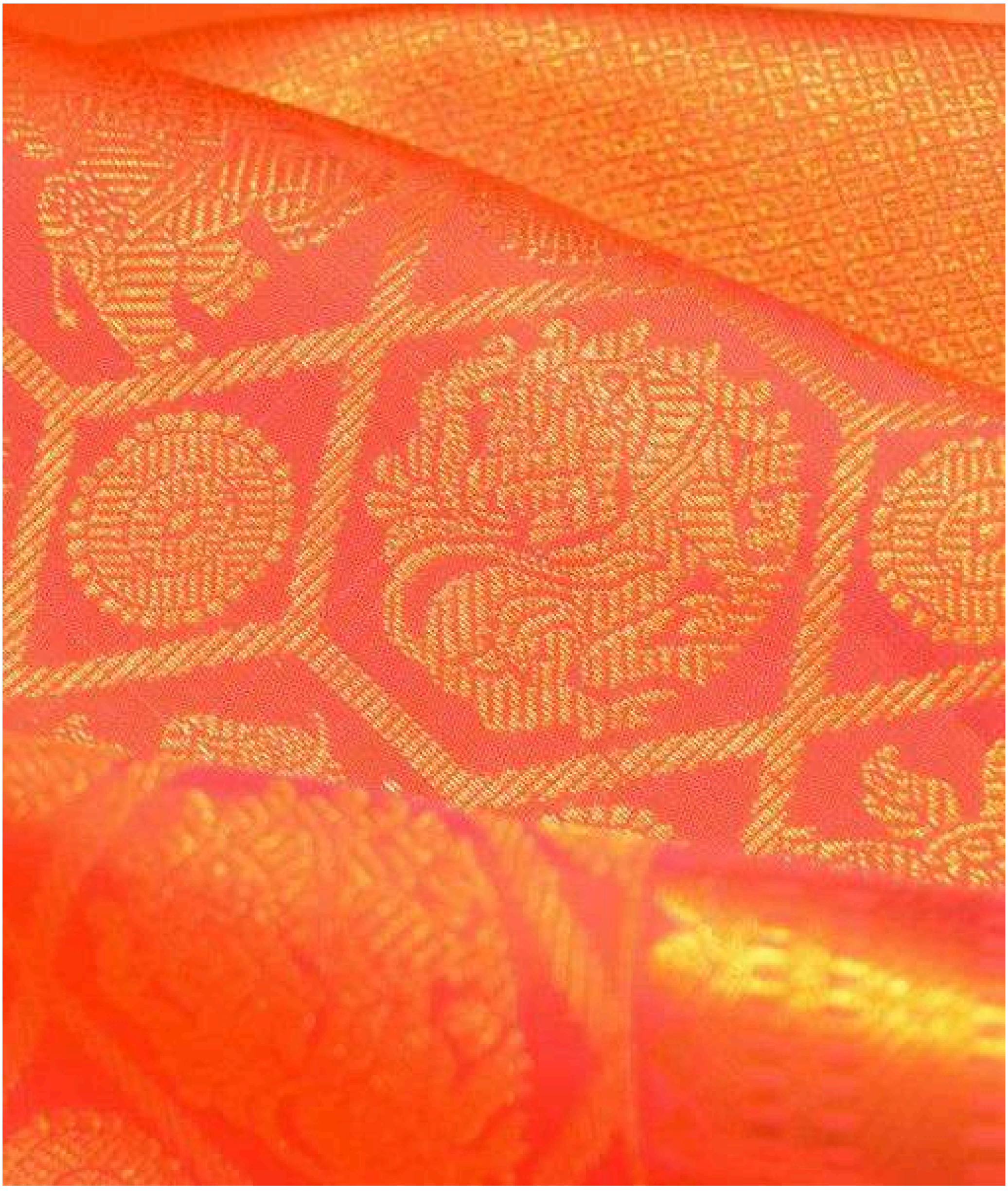
KODI VISIRI, the fanning creeper with curving tendrils.



KUTHIRAI, the mythical, wish-fulfilling, winged horse, frequently seen in temple mandapams.



MAYIL KANNU, the thousand eyes of a divine peacock that shielded Indra from Ravana in battle.



YAALI, part-lion, part-elephant, part-horse,
powerful guardian of temples.



PU-CHAKRAM, circled fields of adornment, across an entire wedding saree or a dramatic pallu.



RUDRAKSHA, Shiva's healing tears for a devotee. Used extensively in borders, stripes or as a richly scattered motif.



IRUTHALAI PAKSHI, mighty celestial two-headed bird. Watching over the whole world in all directions.



THAZHAMPU REKU. The heavenly scent of the riverside screwpine flower is in contrast to its needle-sharp petals! This striking adaptation above, with variations, has also entered popular vocabulary as a 'temple border'.



VAAZHAI THOPPU, a plantation of banana trees, symbols of fertility and prosperity, forms the intricate border of this unique wedding saree. Note the little trees below the fruiting mother tree and the interspersed birds.

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